Who up Quizzing they Bowl?

Reading this entire document is unlikely to give you a full understanding of Quizbowl. It is instead intended as a reference guide for rules and terminology. The simplest answer to "What is Quizbowl?" is "The same rules as University Challenge, except it's 10 points per bonus and there's a fixed number of questions per game". UKQB have a more thorough explanation. Full ACF rules can be found here.

Format

Quizbowl: Format of competitive, *team*, *buzzer* quiz in which correctly answering a *tossup* wins your *team* a *set of bonuses*.

Tournament: A competition event where *teams* play several *games*, in a round-robin format. A tournament will use a single *question set*, and usually consists of *prelims*, *playoffs* and a *final*. Tournaments are held at unis across the country, and last for an entire day (10am-6pm, with a lunch break of course).

Tossup: A *pyramidal* series of *clues* which lead to a single answer. Formatted as *clues*, often with a *powermark*, followed by an *answerline*.

Bonus set: Series of 3 *bonus parts* around some connecting theme; 1 *easy*, 1 *medium*, and 1 *hard*. The first part is preceded by a *lead-in* and "For 10 points each:"

Team: Quizbowl is played in teams of up to 4 people. Teams of 5 sometimes enter *tournaments*, but players take turns to sit out each *game*. At student tournaments, teams usually represent a single university, but *chimeras* may be formed in some circumstances.

Game: A Quizbowl game/match is played between 2 *teams*, who will hear every *tossup* from a single *packet*. The winner of the game is, unsurprisingly, the *team* which scores the most *points* during the game. A *tossup* will be read as a *tiebreaker* if needed. Games last around 30-45 mins.

Scoring

Points: Awarded to teams for correctly answering questions. 15 points for *power*, 10 for a *get*, -5 for a *neg*. 10 points for each *bonus part*.

Power: The first half of a *tossup* may be marked as "in power"; correctly *buzzing* on these harder clues earns the player's team 15 *points*. *Moderators* may indicate such

an event by saying “for power” or “for 15”. “To power” a *tossup* is to score 15 *points* in such a manner.

Get: A get is a correctly *converted* *tossup*, specifically not a *power*.
Neg: To neg is to buzz in before the end of a tossup giving an incorrect answer. This loses your team 5 *points* (the *moderator* may therefore say “neg 5”); and only the opposing team may buzz for the remainder of the tossup. Players shouldn’t be overly afraid of negging.

Bounceback: A correct buzz after the opposing team has *negged*. It is good practice to wait until the very end of the question, since the other team cannot buzz. Failing to wait is described as *vulching*.

Questions

Clue: A sentence *uniquely* describing an answer; contains a *hypernym*.

Hypernym: A general term that describes the type of answer expected e.g. “this country”, “this artist”. Tossups should provide their hypernym as soon as possible. E.g. “This scientist names an equation stating a + b = c” is better as a *firstline* than “The equation, a + b = c, is named for this scientist.”

Pyramidal: *Tossups* are described as pyramidal in that they start with harder/more obscure *clues* and get easier, ending with the *giveaway*.

Giveaway: The easiest *clue* in a *tossup*, the giveaway is always preceded by “For 10 points,”

Firstline: Opposite of a *giveaway*, the first *clue* of a *tossup* should be the most difficult. Such clues might be described as *chestnuts*. “To firstline” a tossup is to correctly *buzz* on this first *clue*.

Powermark: Usually formatted as (*), indicates that prior parts of the *tossup* are *in power*. Should be placed immediately before a word that is a significant clue. E.g. “In this play (*) Lothario …”.

Answerline: Formatted like this, “ANSWER: this is the **answer**”, may be followed by a list of *acceptable* or *promptable* answers.

Bonus part: Short question of usually 2 *clues*, possibly 1 longer *clue*, leading to a single answer.

Easy part: *Bonus part* that 90% of teams of the *difficulty level* of the *question set* would be expected to convert.

Medium part: *Bonus part* that 50% of teams of the *difficulty level* of the *question set* would be expected to convert.

Hard part: *Bonus part* that 10% of teams of the *difficulty level* of the *question set* would be expected to convert.

Accepts: Answers that are not the same thing as the main *answerline*, but equivalently correct in the context of the question. Any correct or acceptable answer is underlined and bolded.

Prompts: Answers that are a reasonable superset of the correct answer. Promptable answers are only underlined. If a player gives a promptable answer, the *moderator* will say "prompt" or read the *directed prompt*. The player then has 5 more seconds to *convert* the prompt. For example, if the answer was "Barbary Pirates", the question would likely prompt on "pirates".

Directed prompt: *Promptable* answers that give the player a specific instruction on the type of answer expected. E.g. "from what country?"

Notes: Questions may be preceded by "*note to players*" or "*note to moderator*".

Note to players: Moderator reads this out to make players aware of something unusual about the answer to this question. Examples might be "*description acceptable*" or "two answers required".

Note to moderator: Should **not** be read out to players - might inform moderator that the answerline is particularly complicated and they should read it carefully to themself before reading out the question.

Description acceptable: Indicates that players need not give a specific answer, but can rather give a description such as "the dog from the Wizard of Oz" (in place of Toto). Many quizzers perform a dab on hearing this note - a tradition supposedly started at Warwick!

Statistics

Statistics (or stats): Summary data about *team* and individual performance at *tournaments*. Basic points data can be viewed on hsquizbowl.org. *Buzzpoints* are another form of stats available for most (but not all) *tournaments*.

PPG: Points per Game - the number of points a player or *team* scored in each *game* they played.

PPB: Points per Bonus - a *statistic* measuring the average number of points (out of a maximum of 30) a team scored on bonuses that they earned.

mBPA: Modified *Buzzpoint* Area Under the Curve - essentially the percentage of words in *tossups* that a player prevented from being read by correctly *buzzing*.

Buzzpoints: Advanced *statistics*, showing where players *buzzed* in each *tossup*. *MODAQ* is used to score and track buzzpoints.

Organisations

UKQB (UK Quizbowl): Organisation coordinating Quizbowl tournaments in the UK. They have a very active Discord server and you can run to be elected to their committee.

ACF: Academic Competition Federation: a collegiate Quizbowl writing organisation that produces 4 *sets* each year. Those are *Fall*, *Winter*, *Regionals* *and* *Nationals*. ACF tournaments use *packet submissions* from participating teams.

NAQT: National Academic Quiz Tournaments: a Quizbowl question writing organisation. *UKQB* does not *mirror* many NAQT tournaments.

Equipment

Buzzer: A system/device that determines which player has *buzzed* first. Physical buzzer systems include *Andersons* and *Kitsunes*. Online *tournaments* / *packet readings* might use websites like buzzin.live or simply typing “buzz” in a chat box.

Anderson buzzers: The black boxes on single cables, that make a nice noise. Very good buzzers, but they are made in America and the company won’t ship to the UK at all anymore. So current ones in use are quite old and susceptible to break.

Kitsunes: 3d printed buzzers with too many cables (ours are sparkly purple!) Made by a Durham quizzer in their college bedroom - so they are easier to get more of, but not super reliable. And they have 2 sound options - quiet or horribly high pitched.

Resources

MODAQ: Moderator Assistant for Quizbowl - a web application that allows *moderators* to mark where players have *buzzed* in a *tossup*.

Note: if you are not finding your quiz practice using resources like these fun, don't do it!

QBReader: Website that allows you to play quiz without anyone to read questions. Types out tossups and allows you to buzz in as normal. Has single and multiplayer modes. Also allows you to search past questions, and sort answers by frequency

Anki: Flashcard application that is actually useful for studying in general, but also if you want to take on a lot of random information for Quiz.

Gameplay

Buzz: A player buzzes by using their *buzzer* to indicate that they think they know the answer to a *tossup*. If they win the *buzzer race*, they have 5 seconds (sometimes longer for online *tournaments*) to give an answer. If the answer is correct, their team gets *points* and a *bonus set*.

Moderator (or mod): Person who reads and/or scores a Quizbowl *game*. Interpreting *answerlines* and enforcing other rules is at the moderator's discretion, although their decisions may be *protested*.

Protest: Players unhappy with a *moderator's* decision may lodge a protest. These will usually only be resolved if it would change the outcome of a *match*. The *tournament director* is responsible for resolving protests.

Buzzer race: Event where multiple players press their *buzzers* at a similar time. The winner of the buzzer race is whoever pressed first, as determined by the *buzzer system*.

Convert: To convert a question is to get it correct, to convert a *buzz* is to not *neg* after buzzing. The conversion of a question is the percentage of games in which it was answered correctly. A *team's PPB* might be called their *bonus* conversion.

Vulch: A buzz on a *tossup* somewhere between your opponents *negging* and the end of the question. A correct vulch out of *power* will earn you disapproving looks from your teammates. Vulching may also result in *vulch powering* or (more likely) *vulch negging*.

Vulch power: Buzzing between your opponent negging and the powermark. This is the only strategic reason for *vulching*, and should only be attempted if the opposing *neg* is clearly in *power* (i.e. on the first line) and you are 100% certain of the answer.

Vulch neg: Result of extreme selfishness where your team misses out on a *set of bonuses* (up to 40 *points* lost!) because you did not wait for the *giveaway* after an opposing *neg*.

Tournaments

Prelims: Seeded initial phase of a *tournament*, *team* rankings (by number of wins) from prelims determine what *bracket* teams are in for *playoffs*.

Playoffs: Second phase of a tournament; high performing teams from *prelims* play similarly successful teams in a top *bracket* and likewise for lower *brackets*.

Final: If no team *clears the field*, the top 2 *teams* (by number of wins) from the top *bracket* will play a final to determine the *tournament* winners. Other players are welcome to watch the final. If one team has more wins, the final will be *advantaged* in their favour.

Advantaged final: Best of three series of *games*, where the advantaged team starts with 1 win.

Exhibition final: If no final is needed to determine the winner, the 4 *topscorers* may instead be invited to play against the winning *team* to “exhibit” the finals *packet*.

Bracket: Like a group in a group stage tournament - each bracket member plays the others once. *Tournament directors* enjoy giving brackets silly themed names.

Mirror: A *tournament* using a given *question set*. Sets will usually have several mirrors, for different locations and *eligibilities*.

ACF Fall: *1 dot* question set - usually the first student *tournament* run by *UKQB* each year.

ACF Winter: *2 dot* tournament.

ACF Regionals (or Regs): *3 dot* tournament; particularly successful teams qualify for *ACF Nationals*.

ACF Nationals (or Nats): Single *mirror*, *4 dot* tournament, held in America, which teams must qualify for at *Regionals*. UK uni teams occasionally attend, but it is obviously very expensive and time consuming.

Clear the field: A team clears the field by defeating every other team they play. That team then wins the *tournament* outright, and there may be an *exhibition final*.

Topscorers: Individual players with the highest *PPGs* in a tournament. Along with tournament winners, topscorers are awarded *book prizes*.

Tournament Director (or TD): Individual responsible for coordinating players and moderators for a *tournament*. Our Competitions Convenor usually serves as TD for *tournaments* held at Warwick.

Eligibility: Different *tournaments* have different criteria about who can play. *UKQB* runs *novice*, *student/closed*, and *open* tournaments.

Novice tournament: Tournament using a *1 dot* question set, only players meeting *UKQB's* *mBPA* criteria are able to play. A great way to try out quizzing!

Student/closed tournament: Most tournaments are open to anyone studying as an undergrad or postgrad at a UK University.

Open tournament: A tournament with no eligibility restrictions. Graduated players often attend so expect a challenging environment.

WaShBowl: Pop culture *question set*, writing is led by former Warwick quizzers; student *mirror* is hosted at Warwick.

Book prizes: Academic, quizzy, or otherwise nerdy books.

Chimera: A team at a student *tournament*, consisting of players from multiple universities if the individual unis don't have enough players. Often have silly hybrid names like City St Southcaster.

Jargon

Chestnut: Has far too many ironic and post-ironic uses to fully define. Perhaps the clearest definition is just "a fun fact". Might sometimes be referred to as something that "*you gotta know*".

You Gotta Know/ Y.G.K.: Hopefully used ironically, referring to something that the speaker believes is an important thing for quizzers to be aware of. Also titles a genuinely useful series of articles by *NAQT* on improving at quiz.

Writing

Uniqueness: A key feature of Quizbowl *clues*, which differentiates it from other formats (e.g. University Challenge), is that every *clue* must uniquely identify the *answerline*. I.e. “This man won his first race at age 18” is not unique - players should be able to *buzz* at any point in the *tossup*, without having heard previous *clues*.

Question set: A set of *packets* produced by some group to be played as a *tournament*. Usually have around 14 packets. Sets may be produced by organisations such as *ACF*; or be *housewritten*.

Packet: A set of *tossups* and *bonuses* (most often 20 of each), conforming to the *question set’s* *distribution*.

Packet submission (or packet subs): Teams entering *ACF* tournaments can earn a discount on their entry fee by writing half a *packet* of questions, according to a *distribution* provided by *ACF*. Warwick QuizSoc pays all student tournament entry fees for members, but we do appreciate people helping with packet subs.

Housewrite: A *question set* written by members of one or two quiz societies, rather than an organisation like *ACF*. May also refer to *sets* written by other loose groupings of quizzer (such as *WaShbowl*).

Distribution (or distro): A specification of what categories of questions will appear in each *packet* of a *question set*. Formatted as follows “European Literature 1/1”, which means each packet will contain 1 tossup and 1 bonus on European Literature.

Difficulty level/dottage: *Question sets* are classified (from easiest to hardest) from 1 to 4 “dots” of difficulty.